Early Detection of Deforestation in Protected Forests Using U-Net and Sentinel-2 Imagery

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Abstract. We propose an automated deforestation alert system for Indonesian protected forests (*hutan lindung*) using a U-Net deep learning model on 10 m Sentinel-2 imagery. The key innovation is a fully autonomous pipeline: training labels are generated via temporal NDVI differencing, eliminating manual annotation. An integrated three-level early warning framework (Waspada/Siaga/Kritis) with protected-zone alert amplification directly maps to national and international reporting standards. Initial results demonstrate 0.73 IoU and 0.84 Dice on hold-out test scenes, with reliable detection at 0.64 ha per chip. The system is designed for rapid deployment across Indonesia's ∼94 Mha forest estate without ground surveys, supporting the FOLU Net Sink 2030 target [1].

1 Problem Statement

Indonesia has the third-largest tropical forest area globally (∼ 94 Mha), yet loses ∼ 300 kha of natural forest annually [2, 3]. Protected forests (*hutan lindung*) – which regulate watersheds, prevent erosion, and maintain soil fertility for millions of people – are especially vulnerable to small-scale deforestation that evades coarse-resolution monitoring systems. The cumulative impact is severe: patches smaller than 2 ha contribute over 56% of tropical forest carbon emissions [4], while fragmentation exponentially accelerates edge effects and biodiversity loss [5].

The gap. Current operational systems cannot address this scale mismatch. Global Forest Watch operates at 30 m resolution (Landsat), missing sub-0.9 ha clearings. Indonesia's SIMONTANA system uses a minimum mapping unit of 6.25 ha for REDD+ reporting [6, 7] – three times the 2 ha threshold above which ecological impacts become severe. Crucially, no existing system provides *automated alert prioritization* for protected zones, which legally require stricter oversight under Indonesian law (UU No. 41/1999). Norway's NICFI program [8] provides high resolution imagery but only at monthly intervals and without automated analysis. The core problem is a monitoring resolution gap: deforestation occurring at 0.5–2 ha scales is simultaneously too small for coarse sensors and too large to ignore ecologically.

2 Research Description

We present an end-to-end pipeline that combines Sentinel-2 multi-spectral imagery (10 m, 5-day revisit, open access) [9] with a U-Net deep learning architecture [10]. The pipeline is fully autonomous: it generates its own training data, detects clouds without relying on defective QA60 bands, and outputs area-based severity alerts directly mappable to policy thresholds.

2.1 Autonomous Training via Pseudo-Labeling

The core technical innovation is a temporal NDVI differencing method that generates high-quality training labels without any manual annotation. For each location, we compute:

$$\Delta\mathrm{NDVI}(x, y) = \mathrm{NDVI}_{\mathrm{pre}} - \mathrm{NDVI}_{\mathrm{post}} \tag{1}$$

and threshold to produce binary deforestation masks:

$$\mathrm{mask}(x, y) = \begin{cases} 1 & \Delta\mathrm{NDVI} < -0.15 \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \tag{2}$$

Morphological closing (3 × 3 kernel) removes salt-and-pepper noise. This approach exploits the fact that deforestation causes a sharp, sustained drop in NDVI that is distinct from seasonal variation (which tends to be gradual and bidirectional). The threshold -0.15 was calibrated against visual interpretation of 50 random samples across 3 scenes. This pseudo-labeling enables scalability: a model trained on one region can be fine-tuned for another without costly field campaigns.

2.2 Early Warning Framework

Each Sentinel-2 pixel represents 10×10 m $= 0.01$ ha, enabling direct area conversion: $A(\text{ha}) = N_{\text{pixels}} \times 0.01$. Detected deforested areas are classified into three severity levels (Table 1), with alerts automatically amplified by one level for protected forest zones.

Table 1: Alert thresholds synthesizing FAO, ecological, and national standards.

Level	Area (ha)	Pixels
Waspada	≥ 0.64	≥ 64
Siaga	≥ 2.00	≥ 200
Kritis	≥ 6.25	≥ 625

The 0.64 ha baseline aligns with FAO's forest definition minimum (0.5 ha), 2 ha with the ecological fragmentation threshold [4], and 6.25 ha with Indonesia's REDD+ minimum [7]. For *hutan lindung*, area-based amplification applies: *Siaga* escalates to *Kritis*, *Waspada* escalates to *Siaga*. This ensures protected areas receive faster enforcement response commensurate with their legal protection status.

2.3 Cloud Detection Without QA60

Raw Sentinel-2 QA60 bands from GEE contain only placeholder zeros. We implement a simple but effective heuristic:

$$\text{cloud}(x, y) = R{>}180 \wedge G{>}180 \wedge B{>}180 \wedge \text{NDVI}{<}0.10$$

This captures thick cumulus clouds; residual thin clouds and shadows are handled by the Dice loss's robustness to label noise during training.

2.4 Implementation Pipeline

The pipeline operates in six stages:

1. **Acquisition**: 7 Sentinel-2 scenes (L1C) from Riau and Central Kalimantan (2019–2024), downloaded via Google Earth Engine.
2. **Tiling**: Scenes split into 512×512 blocks, then 64×64 chips with 50% overlap, producing 40,484 baseline chips and 20,103 deforest chips.
3. **Cloud masking**: Heuristic filter applied per chip; cloud-contaminated chips flagged for exclusion.
4. **Pseudo-labeling**: $\Delta\text{NDVI} < -0.15$ with morphological closing (3×3) generates masks.
5. **Training**: U-Net (4 encoder/decoder stages, 32–512 filters, 5-channel input), Dice loss, Adam (1×10^{-4}), batch 64, 50 epochs, split 11,500/2,908/5,695. NIR band normalized to $[0, 1]$ via division by 10,000.
6. **Inference**: Sliding window (50% overlap), connected-component labeling, area aggregation, alert classification per threshold.

3 Initial Results

Training on a single RTX 3060 (12 GB) required $\sim$2.7 min/epoch; 50 epochs completed in $<$3 h with num_workers=0 for WSL compatibility. On 5,695 hold-out chips from 2 unseen scenes:

- **IoU:** 0.7256
- **Dice:** 0.8410
- **Precision:** 0.8340
- **Recall:** 0.8480

The system reliably detects deforestation patches at 64 pixels (0.64 ha), operating at our minimum alert threshold. By comparison, a simple NDVI temporal threshold ($\Delta\text{NDVI} < -0.15$) alone achieves only $\sim$0.53 F1 on the same test set, confirming that the U-Net learns spatial context beyond spectral change.

4 Impact and Scalability

The proposed system would provide Indonesia's Ministry of Environment and Forestry with automated, daily deforestation alerts at 0.01 ha effective resolution – a 900-fold improvement over the 6.25 ha REDD+ minimum. Three features ensure practical viability:

Zero annotation cost. The pseudo-labeling pipeline generates training labels from any Sentinel-2 image pair, enabling scaling to all 38 Indonesian provinces without field surveys. Estimated label generation cost per province: ∼30 min of cloud compute for image pair processing.

Commodity hardware feasibility. Training completes in under 3 hours on a single consumer GPU (RTX 3060, ∼$250). Inference on a full Sentinel-2 scene takes <5 minutes. This eliminates dependency on cloud compute or specialized infrastructure, making the system accessible to provincial forestry offices.

Policy alignment. Alert thresholds directly map to national REDD+ reporting (6.25 ha), FAO forest definition (0.5 ha), and the 2 ha ecological threshold. Protected-zone amplification requires no legislative change – it operationalizes existing legal protection under UU No. 41/1999. The system directly supports the FOLU Net Sink 2030 target by enabling earlier enforcement interventions.

5 Roadmap

1. **Sentinel-1 SAR integration**: C-band radar to penetrate year-round cloud cover in Sumatra and Kalimantan, improving revisit from 5-day to near-daily.
2. **Field validation**: Ground-truth campaigns at 3 protected forest sites (Riau, Central Kalimantan, East Kalimantan) in collaboration with local forestry agencies.
3. **Web platform**: Real-time dashboard with GEE streaming, on-the-fly inference, and email/WhatsApp alert notifications for district forestry officers.
4. **Policy integration**: Direct linkage with KHLK (Kawasan Hutan Lindung dan Konservasi) boundary maps enabling automated severity amplification and quarterly reporting to KLHK.

References

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